JX Step Sequencer — User Manual

Ticco Ross · Oct 14, 2026

Introduction: the sequencer you played, not programmed

In 1983 Roland released the JX-3P, a six-voice analog polysynth and one of the first synthesizers with MIDI. Hidden in its panel was something few players expected: a built-in polyphonic step sequencer.

It was beautifully direct. You pressed Write, played a chord, and that chord became step one. Played the next chord, and that was step two. Need a pause? Press Rest. Want a chord to ring on? Press Tie. In under a minute you had a moving chord pattern running in time, without menus, grids or a computer in sight.

That simplicity is what made it so creative. Because you entered steps by playing rather than by editing, ideas came from your hands: inversions you would not have drawn on a piano roll, rhythms built from rests and ties, stabs that turned into hypnotic loops. Its pulsing chord sequences became a signature sound of 80s synth-pop and electro, and the workflow still feels fresh today, when so much music is clicked in with a mouse.

JX Step Sequencer brings that way of working into your DAW. It follows the original's behaviour closely:

- **Step entry by playing:** each chord you play becomes one step, stored when you release the keys
- **Rest and Tie** work exactly as on the hardware: silent steps, and chords held across steps without a new attack
- **Write starts fresh:** pressing REC begins a new sequence from step 1, just like the original
- **Up to 128 steps**, played back in a loop in time with your music

On top of that it adds what a modern studio needs: sync to your DAW's tempo and transport, step-by-step editing, four step rates, MIDI mapping, and dragging your sequence straight into your arrangement as a MIDI clip.

Roland and JX-3P are trademarks of Roland Corporation. JX Step Sequencer is an independent product by Ticco Ross and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Roland.

Overview

JX Step Sequencer is a polyphonic step sequencer plugin (VST3 and Audio Unit for macOS, Windows and Linux, plus a Max for Live version for Ableton Live) that works like the sequencer of a classic 80s polysynth. You play chords on your keyboard, each chord becomes one step, and the plugin plays the steps back in time with your DAW.

- Up to 128 steps, with up to 6 notes per step
- Steps can be chords, rests or ties
- Four step lengths: 1/4, 1/8, 1/16 and 1/32
- Follows the host's tempo and transport
- Drag the sequence out as a MIDI clip, or save it as a .mid file
- The sequence is saved with your project

Installation

The plugin installs with a standard Mac installer and runs natively on Apple Silicon and Intel Macs.

1. Quit your DAW.
2. Open **JX-Step-Sequencer-Installer.pkg**.
3. Follow the installer and enter your Mac password when asked. The Audio Unit goes to /Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/ and the VST3 to `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/`.
4. Start your DAW and rescan plug-ins. In Ableton Live: **Preferences → Plug-Ins**, turn on **Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders**, then click **Rescan**.
5. Find the plugin under **Plug-Ins → Ticco Ross → JX Step Sequencer**.

If macOS says the installer is from an unidentified developer, Control-click the installer, choose **Open**, then **Open** again.

To update, run the new installer. It replaces the old version, and your saved projects keep their sequences.

Windows: unzip *JX-Step-Sequencer-VST3-Windows.zip* and move **JX Step Sequencer.vst3** to `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\`. Then rescan plug-ins in your DAW.

Linux: unpack *JX-Step-Sequencer-VST3-Linux.tar.gz* and move **JX Step Sequencer.vst3** to `~/.vst3/`. Then rescan plug-ins in your DAW (for example Bitwig or Reaper).

Max for Live version

The Max for Live version is a MIDI Effect device (.amxd) for Ableton Live 12 Suite, or Live 12 Standard with the Max for Live add-on. It runs on macOS and Windows.

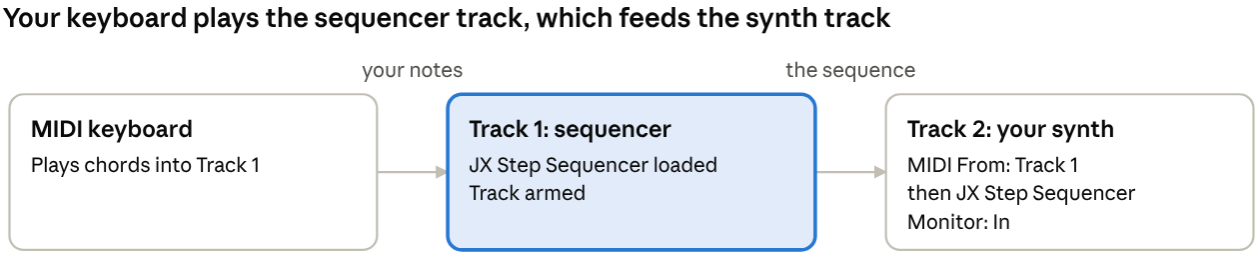
1. Copy **JX_Step_Sequencer.amxd** to your User Library, in `Presets/MIDI Effects/Max MIDI Effect/`. On a Mac this is `~/Music/Ableton/User Library/`.
2. In Live's browser, open **Max for Live → Max MIDI Effect** and find **JX Step Sequencer**.
3. Drag it onto a MIDI track, **in front of** your instrument on the same track.
4. Arm the track so your keyboard plays into it.

No second track or routing is needed: the device passes its notes straight to the instrument after it. Record, play and edit exactly as described in this manual. The device follows Live's tempo and transport, and the sequence and Rate are saved with your Live Set.

The Max for Live device has all the controls of the panel described below except the **HELP** and **MIDI** buttons, which are only in the VST3 and Audio Unit versions. Hover help appears in Live's Info View instead (press **?** in Live's lower-left corner). To MIDI-map a control, press **Cmd+M** (Ctrl+M on Windows), click the control and press a pad on your controller.

Setting up in Ableton Live

In Live the sequencer loads as an instrument on one track and sends its notes to your synth on a second track. Live has no MIDI-effect slot for plugins, so this two-track setup is needed.



Ableton Live routing · 2 tracks

1. **Sequencer track:** drop JX Step Sequencer on a MIDI track and arm it, so your keyboard plays into the plugin.
2. **Synth track:** put your synth on another MIDI track.
3. On the synth track, set **MIDI From** to the sequencer track, and choose **JX Step Sequencer** in the menu below it.

4. Set the synth track's **Monitor** to **In**.

What you play on the keyboard also passes straight through to the synth, so you hear your chords while you record them.

Other DAWs (Bitwig, Reaper and others): place the plugin before the synth on the same track, or route its MIDI output to the synth track.

Using it in Logic Pro

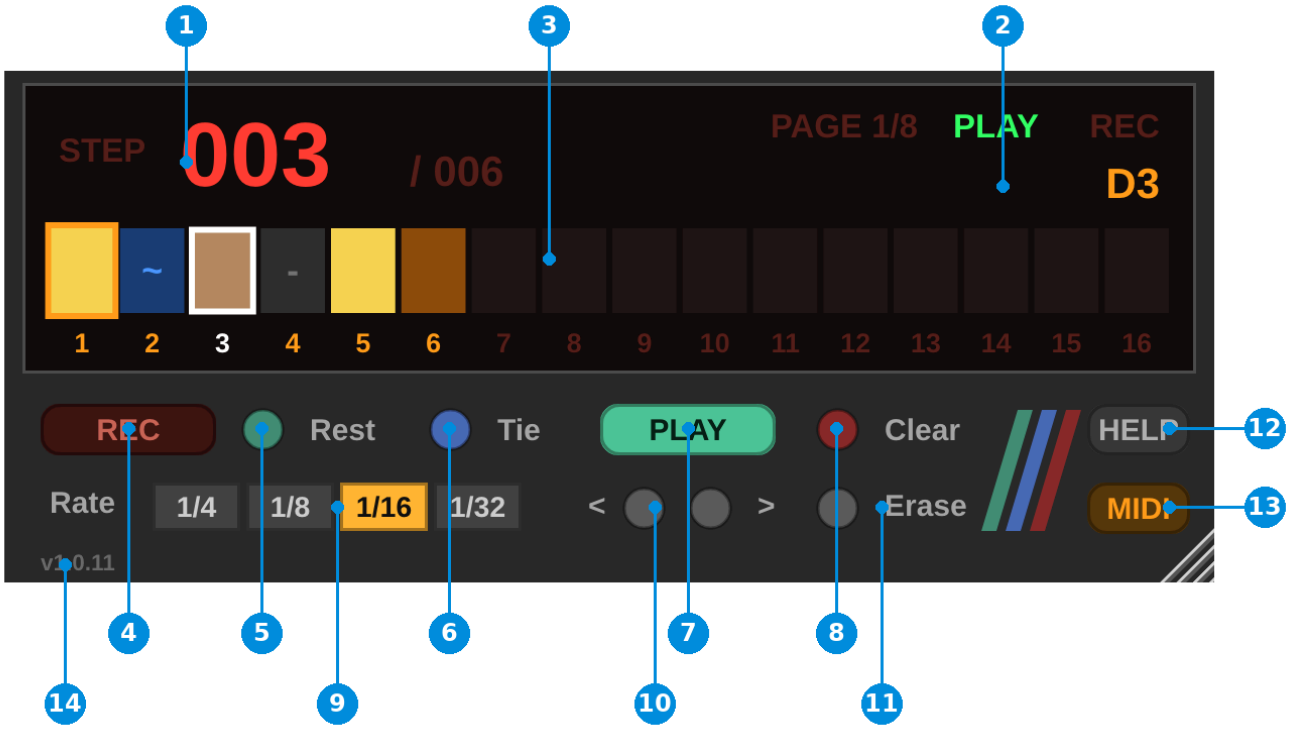
In Logic Pro and MainStage the sequencer is an Audio Unit **MIDI FX**, so it sits on the same track as your synth and no routing is needed.

1. Create a Software Instrument track with your synth.
2. Click the **MIDI FX** slot above the instrument slot and choose **Audio Units → Ticco Ross → JX Step Sequencer**.
3. Press REC on the plugin and play chords on your keyboard, as described below.
4. Press PLAY on the plugin and start Logic's transport.

In the Audio Unit version, PLAY and the other buttons work the same way, and the sequence is saved with your Logic project.

The panel

The panel has a display on top and two rows of controls below it.



#	Part	#	Part
1	Step number	8	Clear
2	Notes of the current step	9	Rate
3	Step cells (16 per page)	10	Previous / next step
4	REC	11	Erase
5	Rest	12	HELP
6	Tie	13	MIDI (drag out)
7	PLAY	14	Version number

The display

Element	What it shows
STEP number (large, red)	The step being played, the next step to record, or the selected step
/ total	How many steps the sequence has
REC / PLAY lights	Light up when recording or playback is on
Note names (amber)	The notes of the current step, for example C3 E3 G3, or REST / TIE / FULL
Step cells	One page of 16 steps. Light yellow = chord (2+ notes), amber = single note, blue with ~ = tie, grey with - = rest
Step numbers	Under each cell. White = playing, red = recording position, amber = selected
PAGE x/8	Which page of 16 steps is shown. It follows the active step

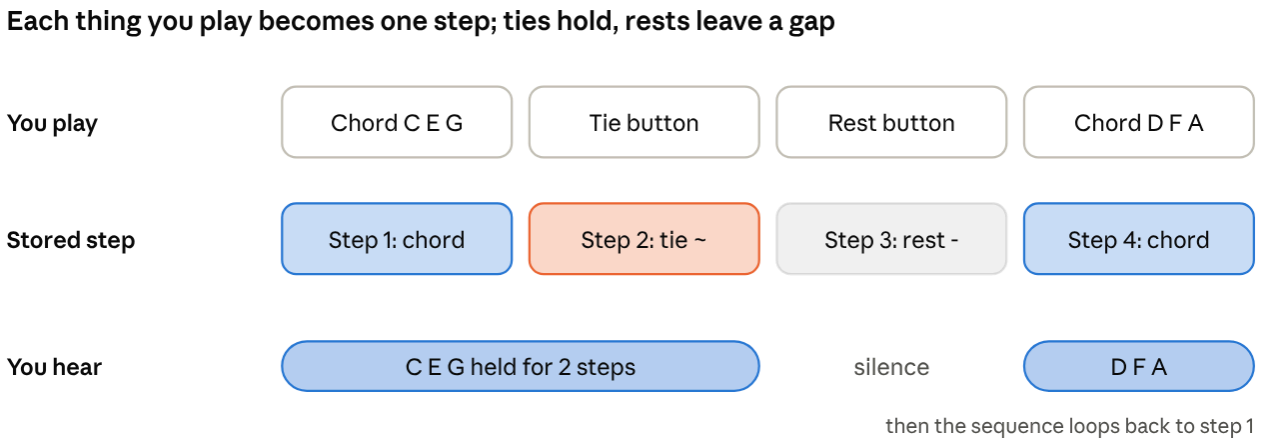
Outlines on the cells: white = the step playing now, red = where the next recorded step goes, amber = the selected step.

The controls

Control	What it does
REC	Starts recording a new sequence from step 1. Press again to stop
Rest	While recording: adds a silent step
Tie	While recording: holds the previous step for one more step
PLAY	Arms playback. Steps run while the DAW transport is playing
Clear	Erases the whole sequence
Rate	Length of one step: 1/4, 1/8, 1/16 or 1/32
< and >	Select the previous or next step (not while recording)
Erase	Blanks the selected step. While recording, removes the last step entered
HELP	Turns the help texts shown on mouse-over on or off
MIDI	Drag out the sequence as a MIDI clip, or click to save a .mid file

Recording a sequence

Recording is step by step, not in real time: each chord you play becomes the next step, however long you take.



How a sequence is built · 4 steps

1. Press **REC**. The old sequence is erased and recording starts at step 1.
2. Play a chord or a single note. The step is stored when you release all keys. The note names appear on the display while you hold them.
3. Play the next chord for step 2, and so on.
4. Press **Rest** for a silent step, or **Tie** to hold the previous step one step longer.
5. Press **REC** again to finish.

Rules while recording:

- A step holds up to 6 notes. Extra keys in the same chord are ignored.
- The velocity of each key is stored and played back.
- Rest and Tie only work when no keys are held.
- Tie needs a note step before it: you can't tie a rest or tie at step 1.
- **Erase** works like backspace: it removes the last step you entered.
- After 128 steps the display shows FULL and recording stops.

Playback and Rate

Playback follows your DAW: the sequence only runs while **PLAY** is on and the DAW transport is playing.

- Press **PLAY** to arm playback. Then start the DAW transport.
- Every time the transport starts or stops, the sequence goes back to step 1 and any sounding notes stop.
- Steps land exactly on the DAW's beat grid, at the tempo of your project.
- The sequence loops: after the last step it starts again at step 1.
- Each note sounds for the whole step. A tied step keeps it sounding; the next note step or rest stops it.

- Press **PLAY** again to stop playback.

Rate sets the length of one step. You can change it while playing, and it can be automated from the DAW.

Rate	Steps per 4/4 bar
1/4	4
1/8	8
1/16 (default)	16
1/32	32

Editing steps

You can fix single steps without recording the whole sequence again. Editing works when REC is off, and also while the sequence plays.

Select a step: press **<** or **>**. The selected step gets an amber outline and its notes show on the display. Selection wraps around from the last step to the first.

Blank a step: press **Erase**. The selected step becomes a rest, and the sequence keeps its length. Any ties that continued that step become rests too, since there is nothing left to hold.

Fill a blank step: select a rest step and play a chord on your keyboard. The chord goes into that step when you release the keys. Only rest steps take new notes, so playing over a note step changes nothing.

Clear everything: press **Clear** to erase the whole sequence.

To change a note step, blank it with **Erase** and then play the new chord into it.

Exporting MIDI

The **MIDI** button turns the sequence into a MIDI clip you can edit like any other.

Drag it into your song: press and hold **MIDI**, drag the pointer out of the plugin window, and drop it on Live's Arrangement, a clip slot or an empty track. The clip starts where you let go.

Save a file: click **MIDI** without dragging. A file named like *JX Sequence 2026-10-13 20-25-56.mid* is saved to `Music/JX Step Sequencer/`, and Finder opens on it. You can drag that file into any DAW later.

What the clip contains:

- One pass of the sequence, at the current **Rate**
- Chords as chords, with the recorded velocities
- Ties as longer notes, rests as gaps
- All notes on MIDI channel 1

The button is dimmed while the sequence is empty.

Help, saving and window size

Help texts: rest the mouse on a control for a moment to see what it does. Press **HELP** to turn these texts off or on; the button is orange while they are on. Help texts are off when you first load the plugin.

Saved with your project: the sequence, the Rate, the window size and the HELP setting are stored in your DAW project and come back when you open it. REC and PLAY are not saved, so press **PLAY** again after opening a project.

Window size: drag the bottom-right corner of the plugin window to make it bigger, up to three times its smallest size. It keeps its shape and remembers its size.

MIDI mapping

Every button and the Rate selector can be controlled from a MIDI controller, so you can record and edit sequences without touching the mouse.

Parameter	Acts like
REC	Pressing REC
PLAY	Pressing PLAY
Rest	Pressing Rest
Tie	Pressing Tie
Clear	Pressing Clear
Previous step	Pressing <
Next step	Pressing >
Erase	Pressing Erase
Rate	Choosing 1/4, 1/8, 1/16 or 1/32

Each press of a mapped pad or button triggers the control once; releasing it does nothing. REC and PLAY switch on with one press and off with the next.

To map in Ableton Live:

1. Click the triangle in the plugin's title bar, then **Configure**.
2. Click the controls you want in the plugin window. Each one appears as a slider in the device.
3. Click **Configure** again to finish.
4. Press **MIDI** (Cmd+M) in Live's top-right corner, click a slider, and press a pad or button on your controller.
5. Press **MIDI** again to leave mapping mode.

In other DAWs, use their MIDI-learn or controller-mapping feature; the parameters have the names above.

Specifications

Item	Value
Format	VST3 instrument with MIDI in/out; Audio Unit MIDI FX (macOS); Max for Live MIDI Effect (.amxd)
Systems	macOS (Apple Silicon and Intel), Windows 64-bit, Linux 64-bit. Max for Live: Ableton Live 12 Suite or Standard + Max for Live, macOS and Windows
Maximum steps	128 (8 pages of 16)
Notes per step	Up to 6
Step types	Notes, rest, tie
Step lengths	1/4, 1/8, 1/16, 1/32
Timing	Locked to the host tempo and transport
MIDI output	Channel 1, recorded velocities, keyboard input passed through
Note names	C3 = MIDI note 60, as in Ableton Live
Automatable parameter	Rate and all 8 buttons (MIDI-mappable)
Audio output	Stereo, silent (the plugin only makes MIDI)

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
The plugin doesn't appear in Live	Turn on **Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders** in Preferences → Plug-Ins and click **Rescan**. Look under Ticco Ross, or type "JX" in the browser search
Nothing plays	Check that **PLAY** is on (green) and the Live transport is running. The sequence must have at least one step
The synth makes no sound	On the synth track, check **MIDI From** points to the sequencer track and JX Step Sequencer, and **Monitor** is set to **In**
Keys do nothing while recording	Arm the sequencer track so your keyboard reaches the plugin. Check REC is lit
Rest or Tie does nothing	Release all keys first. Tie also needs a note step before it
A step won't take new notes	Only blank steps take notes when REC is off. Select the step and press **Erase** first
The MIDI button saves a file instead of making a clip	Hold the mouse button down and drag; a plain click saves a file
Old projects show the plugin as missing	Projects saved with an early test version use an older plugin ID. Remove it and add JX Step Sequencer again